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The Kurdish question in the aftermath of the Gulf War: geopolitical and geostrategic changes in the Middle East

ROBERT OLSON

The Kurds are a people estimated to number some 20–25 million living largely in three Middle Eastern countries: Turkey which is estimated to have a population of 10–12 million; Iran, 5–6 million and Iraq, 3–3.5 million. Syria also has a Kurdish population of around 800,000 and some 70–80,000 Kurds live in Armenia and Azerbaijan.¹ Since the bulk of Kurds live in contiguous areas of east and south-east Turkey, north and north-east Iraq; north and north-west Iran and in east and north-east Syria, they have possessed a sense of self, community and of shared space since medieval times at least. This sense of identity was reinforced by the emergence of nationalist movements in the last two decades of the 19th century and throughout the 20th century. The Kurds consider themselves to be direct descendants of the ancient Medes (although modern scholarship doubts this) who, because of military conquests, defeats and collapse of empires, began to migrate and locate themselves around 2000 years ago in the mountain fastnesses of the present states of Turkey, Iran and Iraq. From these strategic and almost impregnable locations, the Kurds were able to preserve their communities while at the same time participating in the great Armenian, Greek, Byzantine, Arab, Turkish, Iranian and Ottoman empires that dominated this region's history right up to the collapse and partition of the Ottoman empire at the end of World War I. The Kurds were promised the possibility of an independent state in articles 62 and 64 of the Treaty of Sèvres signed on 10 August 1920.

The Kurds, like the Armenians had been earlier, were to be disappointed in attempting to establish an independent state, or even a homeland, in former Ottoman territories. The Armenians did manage to establish an independent state from 1918–1920. This state became an autonomous republic of the Soviet Union from 1920 to 1990. In 1991 Armenia again became an independent state. The Kurds, however, in the aftermath of the removal, deportation and massacres of Armenians after 1915, were left without a buffer between themselves and the Turks. They were left alone to confront the emerging strong nationalisms of Turkey and Iran. The Kurds also fell victim to the great power politics of the UK and the USSR, both of which thought it in their interests to cooperate with the increasingly strong states of Turkey and Iran. Since the UK and the USSR wanted good relations with Turkey and Iran, they acquiesced in Turkey's and Iran's suppression of Kurdish nationalist movements. By 1925 in both Turkey and Iran, major

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Kurdish resistance had been crushed; cultural as well as political activities were forbidden. In Iran and Turkey, laws were passed forbidding the speaking of Kurdish in public.² The only exception to the general suppression of the Kurds during the period between World Wars I and II was Iraq. Iraq fell under British mandatory control in 1920. Although Iraq became an independent state in 1932, it remained under British control until 1958. British policy during this period was to encourage Kurdish nationalism, but not independence. This was a device to aid its control of Iraq.

It was the policy of the UK, which was the dominant power in the Middle East at the time, to use the Kurdish, non-Arab population, which then as now ranged from 15 to 20% of the total Iraqi population, as a balance against the Arab Sunni-dominant governments of Baghdad. The Kurds were to be the cudgel that made Baghdad bow to London. The Sunni Arabs represented about 30% of Iraq's population in 1920. The British intention was to use the threat of Kurdish nationalism and/or independence as a threat to Iraq's government to accept British imperial policies throughout the Middle East. British policy was also intended to use Kurdish nationalism to threaten or, at least, to intimidate Turkey and Iran into not challenging British or western interests and policies in the Middle East, especially British policy toward the Arab countries. British policies toward the Kurds and toward Iraq are the reasons why the Kurds today in Iraq have greater cultural autonomy, including the right to speak and publish in Kurdish and to participate in the provincial administration of the areas in which they live, than in either Turkey or Iran. In the early 1990s, however, language and publishing laws were eased in Turkey. In January 1991 the Turkish government abrogated the law forbidding the speaking of Kurdish in public and there was even talk of creating a Kurdish institute. It should be noted that this seems to have been done with an eye to potential developments as a result of the Gulf war. Since the Kurdish clash with Iraqi government forces in the spring of 1991, the Kurds exercise complete control of the areas they control militarily in northern Iraq and are able to speak and publish what they please.

The July 1958 revolution in Iraq and the ousting of the British eliminated British protection for the Kurds, and intermittent warfare between the Kurds and the Iraqi government has continued ever since. The two most major and recent clashes between the Iraqi government and the Kurds occurred as a result of the 1975 Algiers Accords negotiated between Iraq and Iran. As a result of the Accords, Iraq granted Iran navigational rights to the *thalweg* or the deepest channel of the Shatt al-Arab river. The Shatt al-Arab is the confluence of the Euphrates and Tigris rivers which runs for some 90 miles inland from the Gulf and demarcates the boundary between the southern portion of Iraq and central Iran.

The withdrawal of Iranian support for the Kurds in Iraq led to the collapse of effective Kurdish resistance. Even more damaging to the Kurds was the destruction of some 800 Kurdish villages along Iraq's borders with Iran and Turkey. The villages were razed in order to make a 'security belt' or no man's land between the Kurds of Turkey and Iran with those of Iraq. It is also estimated that as many of 250,000 Kurds were 'resettled' in southern and central Iraq where they were distributed among Arab villages in groups of up to five families. The resettled

Kurds, used to mountainous terrain and a homogeneous culture were now isolated in flat, desert country among Arabic speakers.

The second major disaster for the Kurds of Iraq resulted from their leadership's decision in early 1988 to increase their military support for Iran. As a result more Kurdish villages were destroyed by the Iraqi government. By 1987–88, it is probable that more than 1,000 Kurdish villages were destroyed; some estimates range as high as 4,000. Some sources estimate that by early 1988 up to one-third of the population of Iraqi Kurdistan had been depopulated. After the ceasefire with Iran in August 1988, 60,000 to 70,000 Iraqi troops attacked Kurds they thought had been loyal to Iran in the war and forced another 100,000 Kurds to flee to Turkey; 40,000 of whom were fleeing from Halabja, a small town in northeastern Iraq near the Iranian border, where they had been attacked with chemical gas by Iraqi forces during the middle of March.³

After August 1988, there were more forcible deportations of Kurds from their inhabited areas in the northern provinces. Kurdish opposition groups in Iraq claimed that up to 250,000–300,000 Kurds were deported to other parts of the country. The opposition groups claimed that many of the deportees did not live in the border strip that was incorporated into the 'security zone', but in other areas of the Kurdish autonomous region. From 1975 through 1989, it is probable that nearly 500,000 Kurds were 'resettled' to one part of Iraq or another. Some of the Kurds resettled in 1975 did, however, make their way back north and in 1988 may have been resettled for a second time. One observer has stated recently that perhaps 100,000 or more Kurds were killed or literally massacred in the 1980s.⁴

In Turkey the successful quashing of Kurdish rebellions in 1925, 1930 and 1937–38 coupled with draconian measures suppressed the Kurdish nationalist movement. It was the Iraq–Iran war in the 1980s that led to a resurgence of Kurdish nationalist activities in Turkey. The spearhead of this new Kurdish opposition was the *Partiya Karkaren-i Kurdistan* (Kurdistan Workers' Party) popularly known by its initials, PKK. The PKK is headed by Abdullah Öcalan and is headquartered in Damascus, Syria with training camps in the Biq'a valley in Lebanon. The PKK found its greatest support in the south-eastern provinces of Turkey which stretch along the 200-odd mile Turkish border with Iraq. Between August 1984 and June 1990 a total of 1,771 people including 692 PKK guerrillas, 640 civilians, 330 security personnel, 79 village guards, 17 teachers and 14 village chiefs died in armed clashes. In 1991 the casualties continued to rise.

The PKK received aid from Kurdish organizations in Iraq and support from the Syrian government. Syrian support for the PKK seems to stem mainly from Turkey's reduction of the flow of water via the Euphrates river which runs for several hundred miles through Syria and is the major source of irrigation for agricultural purposes and power plants in central and north-eastern Syria. Syria hopes to use it support for the PKK as leverage against Turkey not to reduce further the water released into the Euphrates by the up-river dams in Turkey. Syria also still harbours resentment over the loss of the province of Alexandretta (Iskenderun) or Hatay that Turkey, with the approval of France, annexed in 1938.⁵ It may be too that by supporting the PKK, Syria hopes to weaken its strong northern neighbour.

From 1983 to Iraq's invasion of Kuwait on 2 August 1990, Turkey and Iraq

cooperated closely to contain their respective Kurdish populations and Kurdish nationalism. Between 1983 and 1988 Turkey, with troops sometimes numbering up to 10,000 accompanied by extensive air power, made constant incursions into northern Iraq, especially in 1983, 1986 and 1987. These attacks were made with the consent and sometimes in coordination with Baghdad. While Turkish military operations against the Kurds in Iraq decreased or perhaps ceased after 1987 until its operations in 1991, Turkey and Iraq seemed to be cooperating against Kurdish nationalist organisations right up to Iraq's invasion of Kuwait. Cooperation between Turkey and Iraq against the Kurds has been rigorously pursued since the Turkish, Iraq and UK Treaty of 5 June 1926 of which 16 of its 18 articles dealt with measures for border security and control of the Kurds.

In addition to traditional concerns regarding Kurdish nationalist movements, by the 1980s Turkey wanted to reduce Kurdish threats to its \$50 billion Southern Anatolia Project (GAP), a vast dam, hydroelectric and irrigation scheme for south-east Turkey in the heart of Turkish Kurdistan. Turkey also wished to protect the two huge oil pipelines from Iraq that ran through its territory to the Mediterranean port of Dörtyol. Iraq also had an interest that the oil pipeline not be sabotaged by Kurdish guerrillas as it became dependent on exporting its oil through Turkey after the outbreak of the war with Iran and its inability to use its Gulf ports. It is these pipelines and ports that Turkey closed with alacrity in accordance with the United Nations resolutions a few days after Iraq's invasion of Kuwait. Many Kurds suspect that the Turkish government hopes that the GAP and its extensive irrigation schemes will improve the standard of living of the Kurdish dwellers in the region sufficiently to reduce support for Kurdish nationalist and guerrilla organisations such as the PKK. There is also fear that the GAP will introduce large-scale commercial and corporate farming into the region which will induce a heavy emigration of Kurds, further diluting the Kurdish population density of the region. This in turn would reduce the ability of Kurdish guerrilla organisations to operate in the region. The Kurds fear that the Turkish government will attempt to settle more non-Kurds in the region in an attempt to dilute further Kurdish population concentrations and their support for Kurdish nationalist, especially, guerrilla organisations.

The Kurds in Iran used every opportunity to gain greater autonomy for their region in the wake of the revolutionary chaos in Iran after 1978. From 1978 to early 1984, the Kurds did manage to secure a great deal of autonomy; more than they had ever experienced since 1925. By 1984, however, the Kurds had also lost some 20,000 fighters in clashes with Iran's revolutionary forces. By early 1984, the Islamic Republic's forces had managed to subdue the Kurdish nationalist organisations, but fighting between the central government and the Kurds continues right up to the present.

The constant challenge of the Kurds to the Islamic Republic of Iran was strongly evident as late as 13 July 1989 when Iranian government agents assassinated Abdul Rahman Ghassemlou, the leader of the Kurdish Democrat Party of Iran. It is speculated that the Iranian government was concerned about the demands of Ghassemlou for greater autonomy for Iranian Kurdistan and deemed it necessary to eliminate him.

The Kurds in the aftermath of the war

The regionalisation and consolidation of Kurdish nationalist groups as a result of the Iraq–Iran war in the decade of the 1980s and the US-led coalition war against Iraq in early 1991 provided the Kurds with their most propitious opportunity to create an independent state or, at least, gain greater autonomy within the states in which they live, since the collapse of the Ottoman empire. There are, however, great impediments to the creation of a Kurdish state that would include the bulk of Kurds living within what the Kurds refer to as Kurdistan. The major obstacle to the creation of a Kurdish state is that an independent Kurdish state or even an autonomous Kurdistan would jeopardise the sovereignty as now accepted of large states such as Turkey, Iran and Iraq: a sovereignty that is very much intertwined with the national history of each of these countries.

Since the geopolitics of the Middle East after the Gulf War seem to suggest that the possibility of the creation of a Kurdish state exists for the first time since World War I, it is necessary to ask why a Kurdish state was not created in the wake of World War I? Secondly, does the aftermath of the Gulf War of 1991 bear any resemblance to the situation created after World War I? As mentioned earlier, articles 62 and 64 of the Treaty of Sèvres called for an independent Kurdish state. But it was not to be. Why? Before we answer that question, we must answer the question as to why the European powers, particularly the UK, entertained the idea of a Kurdish state in the first place.

The major geopolitical reason favouring the creation of a Kurdish state after World War I on the part of the European powers was to place a buffer between the Turks of Anatolia and the Turkic speaking peoples of Central Asia, especially in the Caucasus and specifically in Azerbaijan. It is important to note that the vast majority of Anatolian Turks and Central Asian Turks are Sunnis. It is true that the vast majority of Azerbaijanis are Shi'i but, with this one exception, the Sunni belt stretches from Istanbul to Beshkik (formerly Frunze), the capital of Kirghiza. Given the potential of Muslim unity, although subsequently realised to be exaggerated, the UK as the dominant and, in many instances, ruling power in the region was eager to prevent any such unity from taking place. A second geopolitical reason for the creation of Kurdistan was to create a buffer state between emergent nationalist Turkey and the autonomous republic of Azerbaijan in the USSR. A third reason was to create a buffer between Turkey and the Azeri population of Iran. The Sunnism of a Kurdish state would distinguish it from the Shi'ism of both Azerbaijanis. A Kurdish state would have another geostrategic advantage as far as the UK and other European states were concerned: it would reduce the potential power of all three states.⁶ A Kurdish state that encompassed what Kurdish nationalists considered the Kurdish regions of eastern and south-eastern Turkey would have deprived the new republic of significant portions of its claimed territory and substantially reduced access to transportation routes to the Caucasus, Iran, Iraq and Syria. Indeed, it would have virtually placed a buffer between Turks and Arabs. Much of the water resources, potential hydroelectric and irrigation sources would have been in the Kurdish state. The creation of a Kurdish state would have allowed any of the contiguous states; the USSR, European powers, especially the

UK or France, to utilise the Kurdish state and the Kurdish population against the governments of Turkey, Iran, Iraq and Syria whenever they deemed it in their interests to do so. It also would have allowed any one or a combination of the four states to use the Kurdish state against one another. During the Kurdish rebellions in Turkey in 1925 and 1930, the Turkish government and media frequently accused Britain and the Soviet Union of abetting the rebels. During the Kurdish rebellion of 1930, Turkey also accused Iran of aiding the insurgents.⁷

A Kurdish state, even one confined to northern Iraq, could have proved advantageous in intimidating the new nationalist states of Turkey and Iran. Although the UK finally decided not to create a Kurdish state in its mandated territory of Northern Iraq, it continued to encourage Kurdish nationalism within Iraq. There is no evidence of which I am aware that the UK supported Kurdish nationalist movements within Turkey or Iran after 1923. But, by encouraging Kurdish nationalism in Iraq, the UK was able to threaten and intimidate Turkey and Iran and to compel them to accept or, at least, acquiesce to British policies toward the Arab countries. As long as the UK was in control of Iraq, it encouraged Kurdish nationalism. Although as time passed the UK, of course, supported the less militant of the Kurdish nationalists. The Kurds in Iraq fulfilled the same geo-political purpose as a Kurdish state as far as British objectives toward Turkey and Iran were concerned. The threat of Kurdish nationalism emanating from British-controlled Iraq proved an effective instrument in compelling Turkey and Iran toward domestic issues and from meddling in other countries' affairs. The threat of Kurdish nationalism effectively prevented Turkey and Iran from taking strong actions in the affairs of the Arab countries, especially Iraq. In fact it is probable that the threat of Kurdish nationalism contributed to Mustafa Kemal's dictum: 'Peace at home and peace abroad'; a motto that the Turkish government continues to announce officially as epitomising its foreign policy. While the Kurdish nationalist government in Iran during the inter-war period was weaker than in Turkey, it seems to have had a similar effect on Iranian foreign policy. One of the reasons for the good relations between Turkey and the USSR in addition to the help that the Bolsheviks gave to the Kemalists during and after their war of independence was to prevent the Bolsheviks from meddling in or encouraging Kurdish nationalist forces. To prevent Soviet support for Kurdish nationalism became a priority of Turkish foreign policy especially after Turkey adopted a more pronounced Western-oriented foreign policy in the late 1920s and 1930s.

It is significant to stress, however, that the UK cooperated with Iran and Turkey in suppressing and killing the most ardent and adventurous of the Kurdish nationalists. By 1932 most of the Kurdish nationalist leaders had been eliminated and their movements and followers were brought under control. Sheikh Taha, Sheikh Mahmud and Simko Agha among the most famous were removed from power and in the case of Simko killed, albeit by the Iranian army. The Iranians acted against Simko Agha because they knew that this correlated with British policy. During the inter-war period the governments of Turkey, Iran and Iraq under the British, had agreements that none of them would encourage Kurdish nationalism in each other's country. This meant that Turkey and Iran pursued policies to suppress Kurdish nationalism and the UK, for its own geopolitical and geostrategic designs, choose to encourage Kurdish nationalism in Iraq, albeit of the blandest type.

There were other reasons why the UK did not support a Kurdish independent state in the northern portion of Iraq mandated to its control. Almost all of these reasons had to do with the UK's geopolitical schemes for the Arab countries of the central Middle East. By the time Faysal assumed the throne of Iraq in August 1921, it was clear that the Sharifian family was to be crucial to evolving British policy in Iraq and for the Middle East, excluding Syria and Lebanon where the French were ensconced. It was necessary after 1921 for the British to secure the throne for King Faysal in order to strengthen its Sharifian policy in Jordan and the Hejaz. Iraq was the pivot of this policy. There were many obstacles to the consolidation of British power in Iraq but one of the most pressing problems was to determine the Turkish-Iraq border. The Lausanne Treaty (24 July 1924) had not resolved the Mosul question. It was left to the Anglo-Iraq and Turkey Treaty of 5 June, 1926 to establish the boundary between Iraq and Turkey. The boundary accepted by all parties in 1926 still obtains. If a Kurdish state were to come into existence sometime in the future, it seems likely that the 1926 boundary would remain as the boundary between the new Kurdish state and Turkey.

In order to consolidate its position in Iraq after putting Faysal in power in 1921, the UK had to abandon any ideas to establish or support a Kurdish state whether beyond or within the borders of Iraq. The success of the Turkish nationalist forces also contributed to the demise of the idea of the creation of a Kurdish state which would have included areas where Kurds were the dominant population but not included in mandated Iraq. Once it was decided in late 1921 that Iraq was to be pivotal to the sharifian policy for British control in the Middle East, it was necessary for the UK to abandon the idea of a Kurdish state. The principle reason for this change was that the British determined that the Kurds of Iraq were crucial to ensure the consolidation of British power in Iraq. The British wanted the Sunni Kurds, especially their leadership, both religious and secular, as a necessary balance to the Shi'i Arabs. Indeed Faysal, as a representative of the Sunnis, was even more apprehensive than the British. Faysal stated his fears to Sir Percy Cox, British High Commissioner in Iraq, a few months after assuming the throne. Faysal told Cox that

The question of Kurdistan had further aspects for him as King of Iraq which had probably not been fully considered by us [British]. This was the question of preponderance of Sunni or Shiah with special reference to question of constitutional (assembly) shortly to be convened. As we [British] were aware there was already technical and numerical preponderance of Shiah and excision of a large slice of Sunni districts of Iraq out of state and exclusion of their representatives from National Assembly would place Shiah in a very strong position and filled him [Faysal] with misgiving.⁸

The policies implicit in Faysal's statement of September 1921 were to be implemented by the Iraqi government and the UK up to the final negotiations between Turkey, Iraq and the UK culminating in the 5 June 1926 treaty that determined the final demarcation of the Iraq-Turkey boundary. These policies were basically followed right up to 1958. The question of the relationship between the Sunnis and Shi'is and between the Sunni Arabs and the Kurds was to be the

centrepiece for the governance of Iraq up to 1958. It should be mentioned in this regard that Sir Percy Cox was instrumental in pushing the Iraqi boundary as far north as it is today. Many Foreign Office officials were willing to grant Turkey more territory than was the High Commissioner. For example, the Foreign Office in 1926 was willing to let Amadiya revert to Turkey. In the final stages of the negotiations for the 1926 treaty, both the Foreign Office and the Air Ministry were willing to allow the border between Turkey and Iraq to descend to the hills immediately north of Ruwanduz in order to persuade Turkey to speedily conclude a treaty.

Sir Henry Dobbs, who replaced Cox as High Commissioner in 1923, was as emphatic as his predecessor that the Sunni Kurds were necessary to preserve Sunni domination of the Iraqi government. On 15 March 1925, Sir Ronald Lindsay, British ambassador to Turkey and the principal negotiator in the British–Turkish talks, in order to arrive at a final resolution of the Mosul question and eager to make the necessary territorial concessions to the Turks that he thought would conclude the treaty, asked Dobbs if he would agree to the grant of a ‘considerable’ tract of land to Turkey in order to conclude the negotiations. On 16 March, one day after his conversation with Lindsay, Dobbs wrote his objections to accede further territory to Turkey. He gave strategic, tactical and political reasons as to why Turkey should not be granted more territory in northern Iraq.

The Kurds in the tracts which Turkey desires have been the short anchor of British influence in Iraq. It was only through the solid pro-British Kurdish ‘bloc’ in the constituent assembly that the Anglo-Iraq Treaty was accepted in June 1924. And since then they have consistently supported British policy by their votes and influence . . . a cession of loyal Kurdish tracts to Turkey would engender mistrust of us [British] throughout Iraq, not only among the Kurds but among the Arabs. It would make our position well nigh impossible and would weaken Iraq far more than the pressure of an unappeased Turkey on her borders.⁹

Dobbs then went on to stress the negative effects of the cession of ‘considerable’ tracts of land to Turkey on the ruling Sunni class in Iraq.

The cession of considerable Kurdish tracts to Turkey would enrage and disgust the ruling Arab class in Iraq, who are all Sunnis. For it would upset the balance in the Iraq parliament against the Sunnis and put the retrograde and obscurantist Shiah into power. Rather than that this should happen, the well disposed Arab Sunni moderates such as Abdul Muhsin, the present P.M. [prime minister], would prefer to return to Turkey altogether.¹⁰

Dobbs’s statement makes clear that in his view Kurdish support was absolutely necessary to ensure the domination of parliament by the élite Sunni classes under the aegis of the British. It was necessary to maintain this balance even at the *risk of alienating Turkey*. In addition it is clear that the High Commissioner had a low opinion of the Shi’is. It is also important to note that Dobbs was extremely influential in determining British policy in Iraq during his tenure as High Commissioner from 1923 to 1929.¹¹ During his 6-year term, nearly all of the policies he proffered to the Colonial and Foreign Offices were implemented.

What is important for our topic here is that it is clear from the evidence that after March 1922 and the signing of the Treaty of Lausanne (24 July 1923) is a strong indication of this) British policy did not favour the creation of *any kind* of Kurdish state for a host of geopolitical and geostrategic reasons.

Geostrategic reasons

The success of the Turkish nationalist forces compelled the British to stop supporting Kurdish nationalist forces *outside* mandated Iraq after March 1922.¹² The cessation of this policy was one of the contributing factors to Turkish agreement to commence *pourparlers* with the British in November 1922. After 1921 and Faysal's election as King of Iraq, British policy required that the Kurdish population of mandated Iraq and its leadership was essential for British control of Iraq and hence pivotal for its entire sherifian policy upon which its control of the Middle East, excluding Syria and Lebanon, was based. This policy demanded that the most militant of Kurdish nationalists in Iraq, especially those Kurdish nationalist leaders such as Sheikhs Barzani, Taha and Mahmud who had followers in Turkey and Iran, be removed from power. By 1932 when Iraq became an independent state and was admitted to the League of Nations this had been accomplished. By 1932 Sheikh Barzani was the only Kurdish leader whose leadership was still intact but his power had been greatly reduced after extensive air raids by the British in 1931 and in the spring of 1932.

The other great power that could possibly have gained some advantage in supporting or encouraging a Kurdish state was the USSR. But Soviet relations with Turkey were good, stemming from its support of and aid to Turkish nationalist forces in the early stages of their war of independence. The USSR did not aid the Kurds in their 1925 or 1930 rebellions against Ankara. Even though it was clear to Soviet officials that Turkey was pursuing a pro-Western oriented foreign policy by the late 1920s and early 1930s, they still refrained from inciting the Kurds against Ankara. The USSR did not change this policy until after World War II when it openly armed the Kurds in their attempt to set up a Kurdish state in north-western Iran. At this time the USSR probably would not have minded if the Kurdish nationalist movement had become more active in Turkey. But there is no evidence of which the present author is aware that the USSR actively supported Kurdish nationalist forces in Turkey in 1945 or 1946.

Throughout the inter-war period the USSR preferred strong authoritarian nationalist governments in Turkey and Iran, both of which frequently suppressed nationalists and minority movements. The USSR thought such states would provide the best means of protection and security from the UK. With the exception of France no other country was in a position to support Kurdish nationalism during the inter-war period. But France too had made its peace with Turkey in 1921 and its own preoccupation with pacifying Syria was to keep it fully occupied. Turkey also had the option, which it occasionally used up to 1930 or so, of stirring up the Kurds in Syria. France, however, was not eager to incite Kurdish nationalists after 1930. It is true that the Kurdish nationalist organisation, *Khoybun*, was located in Damascus but after 1930 its actions were greatly curtailed. *Khoybun* did manage

to provide some support for the Kurdish rebellion in the Ararat area in 1930 but it is difficult to determine how much. The Turkish government also continually applied pressure on the French to eliminate the *Khoybun*. In short there was no great-power support for a Kurdish nationalist state after 1922, with the exception that the French tolerated the existence of the *Khoybun* in Damascus. It should be pointed out that France sought to use the *Khoybun* as much against the UK as against Turkey and for support of Kurdish nationalist objectives. In fact Syria's support (under French aegis) for the *Khoybun* bears a resemblance to the current Syrian government's support for the PKK which throughout the 1980s and early 1990s was headquartered in Syria.

The only change in the European powers and Soviet policy toward the creation of a Kurdish state occurred in the aftermath of World War II when it decided for geostrategic reasons to support a Kurdish independent state in north-western Iran.¹³ But the Iranian or Azerbaijan crisis, as it is usually called, of 1945–46 is an aberration in the policy of the USSR during 1921–91 of supporting Kurdish nationalism as a long-term foreign policy goal. Soviet support for a Kurdish state in Iran in 1945–46, whatever one's interpretation of the origins of the crisis, was based on geostrategic concerns in the emerging cold war with the USA, if one accepts Fred Lawson's thesis that Soviet actions were in response to the gradual escalation of US pressure and increasing military involvement in the Gulf, especially during the last two years of World War II, and that the US force posed a 'serious-albeit-indirect-threat to the security of the USSR'.¹⁴ The viability of a Kurdish state and its potential usefulness was probably not uppermost in the minds of Soviet policy makers.

The crushing of the Kurdish Mahabad Republic as well as the Azerbaijan Democratic Republic by Iranian forces after the withdrawal of Soviet forces in the spring of 1946 made it politically incongruous for any European power, including the UK or the USA to advocate support for a Kurdish state in Iran let alone in Iraq or Turkey. After the crushing of the Kurdish Mahabad Republic, the ability of any great power or strong regional state to use Kurdish nationalism for its own national interests diminished for nearly two decades.

After 1946 Turkey, Iran and Iraq (under British control until 1958) were to re-establish their policies of political and military cooperation against the various Kurdish nationalist movements. This cooperation was to persist up to the Gulf War of 1991. This is not to say there was no meddling in Kurdish nationalist affairs by these states. After the Iraqi revolution in 1958 which resulted in the UK being expelled by the new government of Abdul Karim Qassem, the subsequent Iraqi governments, especially the Ba'ath governments that came to power after 1968, were almost continuously at war with the Kurds. From 1958 to the signing of the Algiers Accords in 1975, there were continuing efforts by Iran, sometimes in cooperation with Israel and the USA, to destabilise the Iraqi government. According to Mark Gasiorowski, the Iranian, Turkish and Israeli intelligence organisations cooperated throughout the 1960s and 1970s in efforts to destabilise Iraq. Some of their operations were to support Kurdish activities against Baghdad.¹⁵ While Gasiorowski describes such cooperation only throughout the 1970s, there is other evidence that the relationship between Turkey and Israel continued through the 1980s and is, indeed, probably still in effect. While it is difficult to document how

much of the Turkish-Israeli relationship had/has to do with cooperation concerning Kurdish nationalist activities, it seems clear that such cooperation exists.¹⁶ The Turkish objective seems to have been to elicit Israeli cooperation on restraining the Kurdish nationalist movement in Turkey while Israel was interested in securing Turkey's acceptance of its policies toward the Arabs. Both Turkey and Israel wanted to prevent or limit the cooperation between the PLO and Kurdish groups. Turkey's and Iran's cooperation with Israel in the 1960s and 1970s proffers an excellent example of how each of the two countries viewed the Kurdish question as an indigenous minority or political problem rather than a transnational or regional problem. This was a policy they would come to regret as a result of the Iraq–Iran war (1980–88) and the Gulf War of 1991. Both developments increased the regionalisation of the Kurdish nationalist movement.

The aftermath of the Gulf War

The Gulf War dramatically affected the Kurdish question and the geopolitical and geostrategic role it plays in the Middle East and in the emerging Central Asian political systems. Iraq was the country most affected by the Gulf War. Its rapid and devastating defeat by the US-led coalition forces with the accompanying loss of an estimated 200,000 or more military and civilian lives in addition to the bulk of its air force and army greatly inhibited the power it could bring to bear against the Kurds. In addition to the loss of vast quantities of war material, the government, still in power despite its devastating defeat, was confronted by rebellion in the Shi'i dominated southern and central half of the country, including the sacred cities of Karbala and Najaf. In addition, in the months after the war the government was preoccupied with the repair and reconstruction of much of its communication and transportation systems. It is not my place here to categorise or estimate the human and physical losses of Iraq. Such assessments are still in progress. But what is important to our topic is that in spite of its great losses, the Iraqi government remained in power and was able to marshal sufficient forces to beat back advances that Kurdish nationalist forces had made during the war. By April 1991 the Iraqi army was engaged in a fierce counterattack against the Kurds. By the end of 1991 the Iraqi army had pushed within a few hundred yards of the 36th parallel: the line that the Allied coalition had drawn in the mountains behind which there was to be a 'safe haven' for the Kurds. It was in fact the creation of a *de facto* Kurdish state. The creation of such a zone to be protected by largely European and American UN forces, was the first time in history that an international force had been deployed to protect the Kurds. Furthermore, it was a force stationed on Turkish soil and with which Turkey cooperated. It is notable that Iran wanted nothing to do with this operation. Neither did Iran support the notion of 'safe havens' for the Kurds north of the 36th parallel, probably anticipating that similar such havens could also be established on the Iranian border at a propitious time. It seems clear that Iran was much less eager than Turkey to see a *de facto* autonomous and/or independent zone established in northern Iraq. This is also another reason why Iran was more accommodating to the massive influx of Kurds, some 700,000 to 1,000,000 than Turkey, although Turkey too was compelled to accept temporarily

some 300,000 to 450,000 refugees.¹⁷ In short, by the end of 1991 the Iraqi forces seemed poised to challenge the UN – allied forces, especially the USA's, defence of the 36th parallel 'boundary'. However, throughout 1991 and early 1992 Iraq had to consider the possibility of further allied and/or American attacks, in addition to the expected attacks from Turkey.

The recovery of the Iraqi forces and their counterattacks against the Kurdish forces seemed remarkable given the destruction they had endured so recently. Their success also suggests the severe weakness of the Kurdish national forces and the internal differences among the coalition of parties making up the Kurdistan National Front (KNF), an umbrella organisation representing various Kurdish nationalist forces. The differences between the Kurdish Democratic Party (KDP), led by Masud Barzani, and the Patriotic Union of Kurdistan (PUK), led by Jalal Talabani, were particularly detrimental to a unified Kurdish position. Barzani was inclined, for instance, to accept a lesser amount of territory to be included in the Kurdish autonomous zone than was Talabani. Barzani was willing to accept that Kirkuk and its oil fields would be administered by Baghdad, although there would be oil-revenue sharing with the Kurdish autonomous zone. Talabani was less inclined to consider such concessions. The differences among the leaders of the KNF continued throughout 1991 and early 1992. The fractionalism within the KNF contributed to the ability of the Iraqi government to contain the area of *de facto* Kurdish autonomy to the area north of the 36th parallel to the Turkish border. Significantly, Dohuk, a large town of some 200,000 inhabitants, was to remain outside the proclaimed 'safe haven'.

Iran was the country least threatened by the upsurge of Kurdish nationalism as a result of the Gulf War. The difference between the development of the Kurdish nationalist movement in Iran as compared with Turkey and Iraq accounts for part of this. Unlike Iraq, Iran in the inter-war period was not saddled with a government controlled by a European power using Kurdish nationalism as an instrument of its internal political control and as a means for its regional and global policies. Iran also did not experience the intense Kurdish rebellions that Turkey did in the 1920s and 1930s. The main reason for this is that Iran did not pursue with the same degree of intensity the secular, nationalistic and anti-religious policies of Ankara. The inter-war history of Iran also exhibited more tolerance toward minorities than Turkey, although both countries were intolerant of minorities. During the period between 1920 and 1960, Turkey was much more thoroughly centralised than Iran, which contributed to further hostilities and tension with the Kurds.

As mentioned earlier, the Kurds in Iran had experienced a devastating blow to their nationalist aspirations as late as 1946. In Turkey most overt expressions of Kurdish nationalism, such as rebellions, had been squashed by the late 1930s. Another major difference between Turkey and Iran regarding the Kurds, is that in Iran much of the Kurdish population, outside of the larger cities, is mixed with non-Persian speakers. This is particularly true in Azerbaijan where Kurds and Turkic speaking Azeris intermingle. In Iran the first contact a Kurd has with a non-Kurd is not necessarily with an Iranian. This serves as a linguistical, cultural, psychological and territorial buffer for the Kurds in Iran. This is not the case in Turkey where the first contacts of Kurds are generally with Turks. In the large

cities the perforced intermingling of the different ethnic groups even when lubricated by bilingualism does not overcome the ethnic and psychological compartmentalisation. At times the greater intermingling of the two ethnic groups causes greater friction. I found many more expressions of Turkish-Kurdish hostility during a stay in Turkey in the autumn of 1991 than I ever did during earlier visits dating back to 1963. Undoubtedly one of the factors that contributes to the increased hostility is the greater attention to the Kurdish question in the mass media. This became especially true in the 1980s with greater coverage of the activities of the PKK and Kurdish guerrilla actions and terrorism in the large cities. Yet another reason is the increased contact between Kurds and Turks throughout Turkey but especially in the Istanbul and Aegean regions. Twenty or thirty years ago there were fewer Kurds in these regions. Now they are filled with Kurds seeking work. More than half of the Kurdish population of Turkey is now living or working in the western half of the country outside of the area that Kurdish nationalists designate as Kurdistan. This same distribution of Kurds does not exist in Iran. With the exception of the 500,000 or so Kurds living in Khorasan and those living in the big cities, the bulk of the Kurdish population live in northern and western Iran. In brief, the demographic, geographical, historical, political and cultural situation of the Kurds in Iran is different from that in Turkey. All of these factors have contributed to a more restrained form of Kurdish nationalism in Iran than in Turkey.

In addition to the above factors, the position of the Kurdish nationalist forces in Iran throughout the 1970s and 1980s was more restrained than in Iraq and, after 1984, in Turkey. The primary Kurdish nationalist party in Iran during this period was the Kurdistan Democratic Party (KDPI) which consisted of an alliance of the urban bourgeoisie and the tribal-feudal élite.¹⁸ While there were and are more radical and leftist oriented parties and groups in Iran, they have not played as prominent a role as the leftist nationalist groups in Iraq. The second largest nationalist party in Iraq, PUK, still lays claim to leftist and Marxist principles. Another factor which distinguishes the Kurdish nationalist movement in Iran is that the majority of Kurds live in regions where the *Sorani* dialect of Kurdish is spoken while in Iraq the dominant Kurdish party, KDP, is based in *Kurmanji* speaking areas. *Sorani* and *Kurmanji* are different dialects of Kurdish which are mutually incomprehensible. *Kurmanji* is also the major dialect spoken by the Kurds in Turkey. As a result there is little contact between the Kurds of Turkey and the Kurds of Iran. All of these factors contribute to Kurdish nationalism being less organised in Iran than in Turkey or Iraq. In addition, the governments of the Pahlavis (1925–79) and of the Islamic Republic have pursued repressive policies toward Kurdish nationalism. This is very different from the situation in Iraq where the government under the control of the British fostered Kurdish nationalism, albeit of the blandest version, from 1920 to 1958.

Other than Iraq, where a *de factor* 'statelet' was created, at least, temporarily, as a result of the Gulf War in 1991, the country in which the Kurdish nationalist movement was most affected is Turkey. This article has dwelt at some length on the Kurdish nationalist movement in Turkey. Suffice it to say that after the suppression of the Kurdish rebellions in 1925, 1930 and 1937–38, there were no major Kurdish rebellions in Turkey until the 1980s. There are several reasons for this. First, the brutal suppression of the 1920s and 1930s placed the Kurdish nationalists

on the defensive. The government established an alliance with the Kurdish tribal leaders and feudal lords who cooperated with the government in the suppression of Kurdish nationalist activities. This alliance with the feudal chieftains, although greatly weakened during the decade, has continued up to the present. It is the weakening of this alliance that allowed other nationalist organisations to emerge in the 1970s and 1980s.

Another reason for the quiescence of the Kurdish nationalists in Turkey was Turkey's neutrality in World War II. The proclaimed neutrality of Turkey did not offer opportunities for Kurdish nationalists or for their support by outside parties. It is indeed possible that one of the reasons that prompted Turkey's neutrality was fear that its full commitment to the allied cause would provide opportunities to Kurds to increase their nationalist activities and for external forces to incite the Kurds against the government. Soviet support for the Mahabad Kurdish Republic immediately after the war is an example of what could have happened during the war if Turkey had not remained neutral. The USSR's pressure on Turkey that contributed to the implementation of the Truman Doctrine is another example of the pressure and provocation that the Soviets could have caused during the war. One of the reasons that the Soviets did not interfere or support Kurdish nationalists after 1946 is that their attempt to do so in Iran failed and left some bitter memories in the minds of Kurdish nationalists throughout the Middle East. In the years immediately after 1946, the USSR was also preoccupied with the events of Eastern Europe, its own industrialisation and with the Cold War.

Another reason for the comparative acquiescence of the Kurds in Turkey is that in 1952 Turkey became a member of NATO. This was a clear message to the Kurds as well as to the USSR that Europe and the USA would tolerate Turkey's suppression of the Kurds. As I stated above the attitude of NATO and the USA was very different toward Iraq. NATO had no objections to the efforts of the USA, Israel or Iran to destabilise Iraq after 1958. Turkey's membership of NATO proved invaluable in deterring Kurdish national sentiments and allowed Turkey to employ the necessary force and means to curtail them. In spite of this repression, Kurdish nationalist ideas continued to abound in Turkey and among the Kurdish exiles in Europe from 1960 onwards.

It was with the creation of the *Partiya Karkaren-i Kurdistan* or PKK in the 1970s, however, and its popularity among the young and educated Kurds, that Kurdish nationalism resurged in Turkey.¹⁹ In a remarkable achievement, by the early 1990s the PKK was actually challenging the KDP and PUK for influence in Iraq! The PKK challenge to the KDP was stronger than its challenge to the PUK as both the PKK and KDP receive their support from mainly *Kurmanj* speakers. From its origin in 1974 and throughout the remainder of the decade and during the early stages of the 1980s, the PKK was concerned largely with consolidating its position in the south-eastern provinces of Turkey. During this process it engaged in bloody vendettas, murder, assassinations and terrorism in addition to its guerrilla activities. Many of these acts were carried out against Kurds. One of the reasons that the PKK gained on its competitors can be attributed to the fact that it represents more fully the lower and downtrodden classes compared with other Kurdish organisations in Turkey. Such groups and classes are more prone to accept the leftist ideas of the PKK and its leader for nearly two decades, Abdallah Öcalan. In order to

stay in the mainstream of the political trends current among its followers and potential adherents in the late 1980s, the PKK began to accept some Islamic principles and to express some Islamic sentiments in its programme and in its propaganda.

The PKK suffered a severe blow as a result of the September 1980 military coup in Turkey which brought the Chief of the General Staff, Kenan Evren, into power and eventually into the presidency. One of the first acts of the new government was to begin a massive hunt of all known Kurdish nationalists. Of the 20,000 individuals apprehended and placed on trial 3,177 were accused of 'separatist' activities. Of the 3,177, supposedly Kurds, 1,790 were PKK members.²⁰ This severe crackdown was a blow from which the PKK and other Kurdish nationalist groups did not recover until the mid-1980s.

It was the Iraq–Iran war that allowed the PKK markedly to increase its strength. The reason for this development was that the preoccupation of Iraq and Iran for regional survival took precedence over all other factors. Throughout the Iraq–Iran war, the Islamic Republic, like the Pahlavi government before it, furnished arms to Kurdish groups in Iraq. Syria too continued its support for Kurdish groups against Baghdad and Kurds in Syria were able to supply their compatriots in Iraq with weapons, many undoubtedly obtained from Damascus. Thus the 1980s witnessed substantial changes regarding the Kurdish question that had not existed previously. The entry of the Syrian government and its Kurds constituted a new factor in the Kurdish question with greater implications for the entire Middle East region. But an even bigger change was the full blown intrusion of Turkey into the inter-regional politics of the Kurdish question. The Iraqi government and Turkey had cooperated, as was pointed out earlier, on security measures to contain, control and squash Kurdish nationalism since 1925. Throughout the 1970s there were undoubtedly many clandestine forays by Turkish commandos into northern Iraq before the large incursion of 1983. But the 1980s saw a great escalation of Turkish military actions that adumbrated then announced a change in Turkish policy toward the Kurdish question and toward Iraq itself.

In 1983, 1986 and 1987 Turkey's air force and army made extensive bombing attacks against PKK camps. Up to 7,000 commandos scoured the border areas, sometimes penetrating up to 20 miles, in search and destroy missions. 1983 marked the first time in 60 years, since 1923, that so many Turkish troops were on Iraqi soil. Furthermore, the air raids and commando incursions were carried out with the approval of the Iraqi government. Deeply engaged in the war with Iran, the Baghdad regime had no choice but to acquiesce in the Turkish actions. Whether Baghdad and Ankara had an agreement, tacit or otherwise, that the Turks should bomb KDP garrisons as well as PKK camps is unknown. Iraq was, however, pleased whenever this was the case. For its part, Turkey claimed that it was interested only in bombing PKK camps.

The KDP and PUK interpreted the Turkish incursions, especially the ones in 1986 and 1987, as effectively siding with Iraq in the war and as a result both groups restored frayed relations with Iran. One of the reasons for their poor relations with Iran was that in the early days of the Islamic revolution the KDP and especially the PUK supported Iranian Kurds against Tehran. But by 1987 fears that Turkey was actually contemplating further and more extensive military action in northern Iraq compelled the KDP and PUK and Iran to cooperate more fully. Neither Kurdish

groups nor Iran wanted to see permanent Turkish occupation of portions of northern Iraq, especially the oil fields around Kirkuk. It also must be noted that once Iranian forces entered Iraqi territory in the north-east, Turkey too had fears that Iranian forces would occupy portions of northern Iraq.

Iran wanted to prevent Turkey from occupying the oil fields, but more importantly it did not want a greater Turkish presence on its eastern border. Such a presence would increase Turkey's influence on Iran's Azeri population. Iran still well remembers the 1932 boundary negotiations during which Turkey demanded the retention of a small portion of land offering a corridor to the Soviet controlled Azeri Autonomous Republic of Nakhichevan.²¹ Any additional Turkish presence in northern Iraq, let alone military occupation of portions of it, especially the oil fields, would increase Iranian concerns about potential Turkish influence not just on Azerbaijan, but on its own considerable Azeri population estimated at 9 million.²²

Iran's deep concerns over Turkish military occupation of northern Iraq or even substantial influence over the KDP or PUK raises geopolitical and geostrategic concerns transcending the Kurdish question in all of its dimensions. What this entails is the making of a Kurdo-Azeri question: a question which involves some 45 million people in five different countries. An increased Turkish presence in northern Iraq, however expressed or implemented, is bound to increase Iranian concerns and apprehensions about Turkish influence on its own Azeri population and in Azerbaijan. Iran's competition with Turkey in Central Asia contributes further to its concerns. The demise of the USSR increases the competition between the two countries. Turkish and Iranian political and cultural systems have competed for millenia in Central Asia and increased competition does not necessarily mean potential conflict. But in Iran's view, Turkey's occupation of or greater influence in northern Iraq even via the KDP or PUK would give Turkey an undue advantage in the larger geopolitical and geostrategic arena of the Caucasus and Central Asia: both areas of vital concern to Iran.

It is in the above geostrategic and geopolitical context that Turkey's response to the Gulf crisis and the Gulf War seems to have evolved. The overriding concern of the Turkish government after it realised that the USA intended to use massive force against Iraq, was to cooperate fully with the US-led UN coalition. Turkey implemented UN resolutions decreeing the shutdown of the two oil pipelines from Iraq traversing Turkey to the Mediterranean. This seemed to belie earlier assurances by Turkey to Iraq that the oil and royalties that Turkey received were vital to its national security. Kamran Inan, a close adviser to President Turgut Özal and one of the originators of Turkey's 'Kurdish policy', stated in 1987 that Turkey met 40% of its oil needs from the oil emanating from the Kirkuk oil fields. He added for good measure, however, that it would be unthinkable for Turkey to 'turn its back on the fate of 1.5 million Turkish Muslims living in the Kirkuk region.'²³ The Turkish Muslims to whom Inan referred are the Turkish speaking Turkoman peoples who lived largely in the Kirkuk region and with whom Turkey has historical relations. Turkey allowed its airbases to be used by allied forces to bomb Iraq. There was a debate among Turkish politicians about whether or not Turkey would actually send its army into battle, creating a northern front. While Turkey opted finally not to commit troops to the war effort, it seems that the government was

deterred by military as well as political opposition. On 18 October 1990 Defence Minister Safa Giray resigned; on 3 December 1990 Chief of Staff Necip Torumtay followed suit, subsequently other generals resigned. The resignations were reportedly over the government's policies toward the Gulf crisis, particularly the employment of Turkish troops.

The dramatic change in Turkey's policies toward the Kurds of Iraq in spite of some disagreement seems to have been motivated by several factors. Another development indicating fairly widespread support for Turgut Özal and the Motherland Party (MP) which he headed was that when Süleyman Demirel, leader of the True Path Party (TPP), became the new prime minister after the 20 October 1991 elections, his early policy statements regarding the Kurdish problem in Turkey and the larger issue of the Kurdish question, indicated that he would continue the previous government's policy toward the Kurds in northern Iraq and the same hard line toward the Iraqi government. Indeed, Demirel came to power in coalition with the Social Democratic Party (SDP), led by Erdal İnönü, who had been one of the severest critics of the Özal government during the Gulf crisis and the subsequent war. Indications that Turkey's policy was favouring greater intervention in northern Iraq was confirmed by the fact that the People's Workers' Party [Halk Emekçi Partisi] (HEP) which had joined the SDP in coalition for purposes of the election and which was composed of 22 Kurdish members of parliament was seemingly unable to influence the new government's Kurdish policies, especially toward northern Iraq. At his 11 December 1991 foreign policy news conference, Demirel warned Iraqi President Saddam Husein that any attempt to attack the Kurds of Iraq, presumably by crossing the 36th parallel, would be countered by Turkey. 'That would irritate us a lot,' he told a foreign interviewer. 'I don't think that it can be called a domestic affair. It's some kind of genocide. Definitely we'll not sit and watch.'²⁴

Another factor indicating perhaps permanent Turkish interest in northern Iraq is that the Kurdish nationalist organisations in Iraq became more dependent on Turkey for survival as a result of the war. As the international forces of 'Poised Hammer' and 'Provide Comfort' decreased and the likelihood of their attacking Iraqi forces should they intervene across the 36th parallel diminished, the more dependent the Kurds of Iraq became and will be in the future on Turkey for military protection. This is especially the case if Iraq is able to restore its air force to some offensive capacity.²⁵ The extensive bombing raids that Turkey carried out against PKK bases in northern Iraq throughout the fall of 1991, and especially the heavy raid immediately after the 20 October 1991 election, were done with the approval and knowledge of Masud Barzani and Jalal Talabani. Representatives of Barzani and Talabani himself were frequent guests of the Turkish government before, during and after the post-election Turkish military operation. Indeed, while the actual operation was being executed Talabani was staying as a guest of President Özal in Ankara!²⁶ At the same time Masud Barzani made statements to the press that if Turkey's air operations continued, the Kurds, at least the KDP, was prepared 'to go to war with Turkey'.²⁷ Barzani also stated that he thought one of the aims of Turkey's incursion was to sabotage the autonomy talks that the Kurds, especially the KDP and PUK, were having with Baghdad.

It is possible that Barzani's comments also were directed at his own Kurdish

constituents as well as at Ankara. But the post-election Turkish military operations into northern Iraq pointed up the dilemma of the Kurdish nationalist forces in Iraq and in Turkey. While the leaders of the major Kurdish nationalist organisations in Iraq were cooperating with Turkey to annihilate the PKK camps in northern Iraq (the PUK apparently more eagerly so than the KDP), some of the HEP members of the SDP, in coalition with the TPP, remained avid supporters of the PKK.

It is appropriate at this juncture to ask, What is Turkey's policy toward the Kurdish question and specifically toward the Kurds in Iraq and Turkey? First, Turkey's changing relationship with the Kurds in northern Iraq should be considered. The Gulf War proffered an opportunity to establish the kind of influence in northern Iraq that it had not been able to exercise since the end of World War I. It should also be noted that the influence that Turkey now exercises in northern Iraq as a result of the Gulf War is greater than that before 1923. The Turkish presence in northern Iraq in the early 1920s was that of a severely weakened empire and of an as yet unconsolidated new republic opposed by the great powers of the time. The influence that Turkey began to yield as a result of the Gulf war is that of a strong regional power whose entry into northern Iraq was supported by Western powers and ironically by some Arab states. Turkey's stronger role in northern Iraq has also been facilitated by the collapse of the USSR. It is true that the USSR aided the Turkish nationalists in their war of independence and by doing so helped them to contain Kurdish resistance. But it is also true that subsequently the USSR exercised the ability to support Kurdish nationalist groups against Ankara if it had so chosen. However, as discussed above, for various reasons this did not occur. Nevertheless the collapse of the USSR has increased substantially the leverage of Turkey with regard to the Kurds, especially in northern Iraq. Rather than having Soviet power right on its borders, Turkey has four Turkic-Muslim states in Central Asia all of which seek good relations with Ankara and none of which would like to see a Kurdish state established, by whatever means, between them and Turkey. Turkey strongly supports this policy as well. Russia in the 1990s will simply not be able to exercise or influence Turkey's policies with regard to the Kurdish question in the same manner as the USSR did.

Turkey obviously saw its best interests were in cooperating fully with the coalition forces aligned against Saddam Husein because of its ties with the West, NATO and the USA, especially once it realised that massive force was to be used against Iraq. Turkish officials were probably made aware early on that the USA intended to destroy much of the civilian infrastructure as well as the military structure of Iraq. It is quite probable that Turkish officials thought that such actions would bring about the collapse not only of Saddam Husein but of the Ba'th party itself. The collapse of the Ba'th party would have meant that the Kurds of northern Iraq would have been in a good position to establish an independent state in northern Iraq. This was an eventuality that Turkey wanted to prevent at all costs. Such a state would prove to be too attractive to its own Kurds and greatly increase Turkey's domestic problems. It is probable that Turkey also thought that even without the collapse of the Ba'th party and/or its Sunni base, or even of Saddam Husein, Iraq would be so weakened by the allied, especially US, bombing attacks, that it would be some time before Iraq would be able to exercise control over northern Iraq, especially the areas close to the Turkish border. This would allow the Kurds of

northern Iraq to gain full autonomy. It would also create a situation in which the Kurds of northern Iraq, through collusion or weakness, would be compelled to give sanctuary to PKK guerrillas fleeing Turkey. This did occur and throughout 1991 Turkey staged military incursions and air raids into northern Iraq to destroy the PKK camps.

The price Barzani and Talabani had to pay for the cessation of Turkish air strikes, which was weakening their position with their own followers, was to promise Ankara that they would provide no sanctuary, comfort, aid or weapons to the PKK. Furthermore, no Kurdish nationalist organisation in Iraq was to give aid to or encourage any of the Kurdish nationalist organisations or groups among the Kurds in Turkey. By the end of 1991 Barzani and Talabani seemed to accept these conditions and indirectly to have accepted a large degree of Turkish influence over their movement in northern Iraq. The economic, food and fuel boycott against the Kurds of the Baghdad regime made the Kurds of northern Iraq even more dependent on Turkey. The irony of this is that Ankara's leverage against Baghdad, and not just with regard to the Kurdish question, was strengthened greatly. These events in turn increased Turkey's weight in regional affairs. A strong Turkish influence in northern Iraq would compel Saudi Arabia and Kuwait to become more tolerant of Turkey's interests in the region.

Still, the question must be asked, 'Why did Turkey so ardently seek greater influence over northern Iraq and the Kurds there given its own Kurdish problem?' The first reason, as mentioned above, is that Turkey feared the nationalist effects of an independent state or a fully autonomous Kurdish entity in northern Iraq. In the circumstances created by the Gulf War Turkey needed to assure its own geostrategic and geopolitical control over northern Iraq. First, it wanted to prevent Iran from gaining greater influence over the region; something that nearly happened during the Iraq-Iran war. Kirkuk and its oil fields lie much closer to Iran than to Turkey. Turkey wanted to position itself to be able to exercise greater influence and achieve greater access to the same oil fields. By strengthening its position with the Kurdish nationalist groups in Iraq, Turkey was also strengthening its ability, if need or opportunity arose, to occupy the oil fields. It should be pointed out that good Turkish relations with independent Azerbaijan and its oil sources could reduce its need and desire for the oil of Kirkuk. However, in Azerbaijan as well as in northern Iraq, Turkey will have to compete with Iran for influence. Turkey will have to consider seriously whether the potential negative effects on its own Kurdish problem outweigh the positive aspects of securing access to the oil of Kirkuk. If Turkey continues to maintain good relations with Saudi Arabia and Kuwait it will also have this means for securing sufficient oil for its needs. However, a change in relations with Saudi Arabia or Kuwait could easily close this source. It would be in Turkey's interest to have a source of oil contiguous with Turkey's land mass. The possession of the Kirkuk oil fields would facilitate greatly the consolidation of Turkey as a formidable regional power. In short, it could very well be Turkey's position that if it is going to have a Kurdish problem, it may as well have it with oil.

Another reason for Turkey's aggressive actions and policies during and after the Gulf War is that they had the green light from the European countries and the USA and even from Arab mentors of the coalition against Iraq, notably Saudi Arabia and Kuwait. While the reasons as to why Europe and the USA would

encourage Turkish actions in northern Iraq are beyond the scope of this article, it seems that the Turks certainly thought they had the acquiescence of the West. Some media reports in Turkey and the West suggested that in return for the West's acceptance of its Kurdish policy, Turkey would act as a stabilising force in the Caucasus and in Central Asia. In this scenario Europe and the USA see secular Turkey as an active competitor in the Caucasus against the Islamic appeal of Iran.²⁸ Turkey's increased cultural, political and economic relations and influence in the Turkic-Muslim Central Asian republics could also ease the disappointment it feels by being rejected by the EC, its diminishing role in European security and in European affairs generally.²⁹ It is also possible that Europe and the USA are prepared to acquiesce in greater Turkish control over northern Iraq and greater access to the oil fields of Kirkuk. More importantly, Europe and the USA realise that such influence over northern Iraq and the Kurdish nationalist organisations in Iraq would allow Turkey more time to deal with its own Kurdish problem—time that it needs desperately if it is to play as strong and aggressive a role in the affairs of the Caucasus and Central Asia as the West desires.

As far as its own Kurdish problem is concerned, Turkey has decided, at least for the time being, to attempt to restrain the Kurdish nationalist forces through democracy. While slogans and mottoes of all kinds emphasising the virtues of democracy have been cardinal stock of the political élite in Turkey for years, the emphasis on democracy in the political arena since 1980 has been made increasingly with the Kurdish question in mind. This entails, ironically, the increased intrusion of Islam into public and political life. The Islamic emphasis and the constant public eulogy of democracy have been part of a campaign to contain Kurdish nationalism. Of course, the Islamic emphasis has had other objectives as well: (i) to curry favour with Saudi Arabia and the United Arab Emirates in order to secure aid; (ii) to reduce the appeal of the left, and (iii) to allow a 'normalization' of religious expression in the body politic.

Some sources indicate that the Turkish government began a policy of allowing or co-opting Kurds and Kurdish nationalist groups into the 'democratic' process as early as the mid-1980s.³⁰ Doğu Perinçek, a parliamentary candidate in the October elections and the leader of the Socialist Party (SP), stated that talks between Turkish intelligence officials and various Kurdish leaders, both within and outside Turkey, had begun in 1987 and possibly earlier. Perinçek also stated that these talks had the blessing of Washington: 'Washington was the protector of Turkey and Turkey the protector of the Kurdistan Front'. He went on to say that the People's Workers' Party (HEP), a party composed of Kurds from south-eastern Turkey, and which, as mentioned above, joined the SDP in coalition for the 20 October elections, was actually 'created by the Turkish government which provided two billion Turkish lira to get it going.'³¹ According to Perinçek, 'the object of the creation of the HEP was to fragment the anti-imperialist Kurdish forces (anti-empyrialist Kürt güçlerini tecrit etmekti).' The creation of the HEP would allow politically organised Kurds in Turkey a nationalist alternative to the PKK. But in order to achieve any influence, they would have to form a coalition with another political party. The only political party close to the political ideology they professed was the SDP, ironically led by the son of the late İsmet İnönü, who was the Prime Minister of Turkey during the massive repression of the Kurds in the 1920s and

1930s. As mentioned earlier, the HEP did join the SDP for the 20 October elections and the SDP subsequently joined the TPP to form a government. Furthermore, İnönü was quite candid in this regard. He was quoted as saying, 'I am performing a national duty. I am bringing them [the Kurds] into unity.'³² Perinçek states that he and his party warned the HEP that there would be an early election in which they would be able to organise in as many of the electoral districts as possible. But the HEP failed to do so. This is further evidence, as far as Perinçek is concerned, that the HEP was created to do the government's bidding. If one of the goals of the HEP was to be at the centre of power, they achieved it. After the 20 October election, the SDP joined the TPP in coalition to form the new government and brought the 22 Kurdish members of the HEP with it.

It is difficult to sort out how much is true of what Perinçek stated regarding the creation of the HEP. It is also difficult to determine to what extent, if any, Masud Barzani or Jalal Talabani were involved in or aware of the proceedings that led to the establishment of the party. It is quite possible, given the straitened circumstances of the Kurds in south-eastern Turkey, the continued warfare between the Kurds and the Turkish military apparatus, and the virtual civil war between Kurdish militia and the PKK guerrillas, that Kurdish politicians decided that the Kurds in Turkey, and especially in south-eastern Turkey, needed an alternative legal political organisation that could compete with the PKK.

The creation of the HEP also served to reduce European criticism of Turkey's violation of Kurdish political and human rights. Turkey's treatment of Kurds was a constant thorn in Turkish–European relations. In many instances the Europeans use human rights violations as an excuse to exclude and distance Turkey from European affairs. The creation of the HEP also provided the KDP and PUK with a legal Kurdish party with which they could deal other than the 'terrorist' PKK.

Conclusion

In order to maintain stability in Turkey, the government must contain and control the Kurdish nationalist movement in that country as well as the Kurdish nationalist movement in northern Iraq. Obviously the control of the movement in Turkey is easier than in northern Iraq. The Gulf crisis and the Gulf War at once made Ankara's dilemma greater but it also offered some opportunities with regard to its own Kurdish problem as well as the inter-regional Kurdish question. As a result of the Gulf War, Turkey became directly involved in the affairs of some three million Kurds in northern Iraq.

Turkey could not allow an independent state to be created in northern Iraq. In order to make absolutely sure this did not occur, Ankara had to seek means and develop policies that would give it more influence over the Kurdish nationalist groups in Iraq, especially the KDP and PUK, the former being the most conservative of all the eight major Kurdish nationalist organisations in the Kurdistan Front. The threats of the Baghdad regime against the KDP and PUK paradoxically facilitated the development of relations between the two major Kurdish nationalist parties and Ankara. A Kurdish state or even a fully autonomous region in northern Iraq

would have an irresistible appeal to the Kurds in Turkey, especially in the south-eastern provinces. The consequences of the Gulf War and the need of the Kurdistan Nationalist Front for protection from Iraqi forces and their need for food, fuel, medicine and other supplies compelled the KDP and PUK to accept aid from Turkey. This 'humanitarian' aid continued to flow south during the early months of 1992. The KDP and PUK in turn were compelled to accept Turkish military incursions and air raids into northern Iraq in search and destroy missions against the PKK. The KDP and PUK, especially the former, were probably not unhappy at having the PKK's growing presence and appeal in northern Iraq reduced, if not eliminated. The Turkish ultimatum to Barzani and Talabani was clear: in order to continue to receive necessary supplies and 'protection' they would have to accept Turkish military raids against the PKK camps in Iraq. It was not lost on the two Kurdish leaders that operations 'Poised Hammer' and 'Provide Comfort I and II', the allied military forces created to protect the Kurds from the regime of Saddam Husein, were stationed on Turkish soil. The KDP and PUK also assured Ankara that neither of the organisations would support or encourage Kurdish nationalist groups in Turkey, although Ankara would allow communication between them and HEP.

Turkey's policies toward the Kurdish nationalist movement became more discernible in the aftermath of the Gulf War:

- (1) Support the KDP and PUK in northern Iraq.
- (2) Compel the KDP and PUK to stop all support of the PKK and other Kurdish nationalist organisations in Turkey.
- (3) Separate the Kurdish nationalist groups of Turkey and Iraq as much as possible, even to the extent of creating a *cordon sanitaire* by demolishing and evacuating Kurdish villages close to the Iraqi border. This no man's land would be similar to the one Iraq created along its Turkish and Iranian borders in the 1980s.
- (4) To use whatever military force necessary to eliminate the PKK in northern Iraq and within Turkey.
- (5) To provide political avenues to the Kurds in Turkey to create political parties and to participate more fully in the political process.
- (6) To marginalise the Kurds as much as possible within the political system after they had agreed to accept its 'legitimacy'.
- (7) To allow a continued emphasis on Islam in order to co-opt part of the Kurdish population and to reduce the appeal of leftist parties to Kurds.
- (8) To improve the standard of living of the Kurds in south-eastern Turkey through increased industrialisation, public works and agriculture resources via the GAP.

The major questions which Turkey faces as a result of its policies toward the Kurdish nationalist movements after the Gulf War are: Will it be able to contain sufficiently the diverse Kurdish nationalist movements in Turkey as well as influence to its own advantage the Kurdish nationalist groups in Iraq? Moreover, will it be able to manage the confluences and the divergencies of the Kurdish nationalist movement and organisations in Turkey as well as the Kurdish nationalist movements in Iraq and the various parties and groups represented in them? Lastly, did Turkey begin its 'liberalisation' policy too late to be able to control or influence for its own national interests the surging elements of Kurdish nationalism in all of its

manifestations? These are the questions that will dominate the decade of the 1990s.

Developments in late 1991 and early 1992 were indicative of the regionalisation of the Kurdish question since 1980. In the autumn of 1991 Syria was sheltering the leadership of the PKK in Damascus and its training camps in Lebanon. The Asad regime facilitated the PKK in its operations against targets in Turkey. The Iraqi regime of Saddam Husein was supplying weapons to the PKK guerrillas both within Iraq and in Turkey. During the last part of October 1991 it appeared that Iran too was supplying weapons to the PKK. In late October, a Greek Cypriot flagged frigate, the *Cape Meleas* was stopped by the Turkish navy as it prepared to enter the Bosphorus coming from Bulgaria. Upon inspection, it was found to be loaded with weapons, including some two thousand stinger missiles. At first it was speculated that the weapons were intended for the PKK via Syria and the frigate's announced port of entry was one of Syria's eastern Mediterranean ports. But within a few days the Iranian ambassador came forward saying that the cargo was Iranian; he did not say for whom it was intended. The impression was left that perhaps the weapons were intended for the PKK to be sent via Syria. Whether or not Iran intended the weapons for the PKK or not, Turkey could no longer rule out the fact that Iran was unhappy with Ankara's policies in northern Iraq and the increase of its influence there as well as the implications of that influence. After the incident there was a noticeably cooler attitude toward Turkey in the editorials of leading Iranian newspapers.

On 25 December 1991 another harbinger of the coming decade occurred when PKK members bombed a department store in Bakirköy, a large suburb of Istanbul. Eleven people were killed and 17 injured; another 70 were taken into custody. The store's owner was the brother of the governor extraordinaire of the 13 south-eastern and eastern provinces in which the Kurdish insurgency is the strongest. This was the first major declared attack of the PKK in either Istanbul or Ankara and marked a decisive escalation of PKK activities outside the south-eastern provinces. It was also directed at an individual whom the PKK views as one of the main formulators of the policies of suppression directed against them. The PKK leader, Abdallah Öcalan, had been threatening such action since early August after the first major Turkish incursion against PKK camps in northern Iraq. Öcalan increased his threats after the 20 October election when it was clear that the new government of Süleyman Demirel and Erdal İnönü was going to continue the policies of the previous government *vis-à-vis* the Kurds. Such policies reaffirm to the Kurds the validity of the saying in the Middle East: 'Love the Kurds of your neighbour [country] and beat your own Kurds at home.' The implementation of such a policy in Turkey, Iraq, Iran and Syria in the coming decade will enhance further the saliency of the geopolitical and geostrategic implications of the Kurdish question for Middle Eastern and world politics.

The great impact of the Gulf War on the Kurdish question became even clearer in March 1992. Kurdish nationalist uprisings on 21 March during the celebration of the New Year's holiday centred in Jizre on the Iraqi border in south-eastern Turkey left scores dead. The rebellion was not completely crushed until 1 April. The Turkish government was forced to deploy around 120,000 troops against the Kurds. Turkish commandos made house to house searches throughout the areas

of rebellion. Süleyman Demirel, the Turkish prime minister, was quoted as saying that, if necessary, Turkey would place a soldier every metre along the Turkish–Iraqi border. What Demirel did not say was how the Kurdish nationalist movement within Turkey would be controlled on the Turkish side of the border.

Turkey's predicament became clearer after the elections in the middle of May to elect a parliament for the Kurds in the portions of northern Iraq under Kurdish and allied control. After the elections there could be little doubt even in the minds of the least suspicious Turkish authorities that the policy of Europe, the USA, Russia and Japan was to support an independent Kurdish state when political circumstances are favourable. This is a policy that is bound to exacerbate the Kurdish problem within Turkey and the Kurdish question throughout the Middle East. It will also provide an impetus to the Kurdish nationalist movement throughout the Middle East as well as in Europe. Such developments will in turn compel Turkey to become further involved in the political, military and economic affairs of Iraqi Kurdistan and in the state of Iraq itself. Turkey's deep involvement in the affairs of Iraq as a result of the Gulf War of 1991 with the approval of the West, Russia and Japan is one of the more remarkable changes in the post-World War I history of the Middle East. It is certainly the most profound geopolitical and geostrategic change in the Middle East brought about as a result of the Gulf War.

Notes

- ¹ Kurdish sources claim the Kurdish population in 1990 was 27.4 million with the following distribution: Turkey 14.3; Iran 6.7; Iraq 4.7; Syria 1.4; former countries of USSR 300,000. The respective percentage of Kurds among the total population of the above countries according to the above percentages would be: 25% for Turkey; 12% for Iran; 25% for Iraq; 12% for Syria. See *Kurdish Times*, 4 (1&2), 1991, p. 21. Some Turkish sources also put the Kurdish population of Turkey at around 15 million. This is the figure given usually by Dogu Perinçek, the leader of the Socialist Party in Turkey and a parliamentary candidate in the 20 October 1991 elections.
- ² On the early phases of Kurdish nationalism see Robert W Olson, *The Emergence of Kurdish Nationalism: 1880–1924*, Austin: University of Texas Press, 1991.
- ³ Anthony Cordesman & Abraham Wagner, *The Lessons of Modern War: The Iran–Iraq War, Vol II*, Boulder: Westview Press, 1990, p. 371 make the claim that Iran may also have fired cyanide shells into Halabja. However, almost all scholars and observers are of the opinion that the gas attack on Halabja was perpetrated strictly by Iraqi forces.
- ⁴ *The Middle East and North Africa: 1990: Iraq*, London: Europa Publications, 1989, p. 473.
- ⁵ For the origins of the PKK see Michael Gunter, *The Kurds in Turkey: A Political Dilemma*, Boulder: Westview Press, 1990, pp 57–96. The data in this paragraph was taken from Suha Bolukbasi, 'Ankara, Damascus, Baghdad, and the Regionalization of Turkey's Kurdish secessionism', *Journal of South Asian and Middle Eastern Studies*, xiv (4) 1991, pp 15–16.
- ⁶ For these developments after World War I see Olson, *The Emergence of Kurdish Nationalism*, pp 128–152.
- ⁷ In my research I have found no evidence to support these claims. See Olson, *The Emergence of Kurdish Nationalism*, pp 122–132. The Turkish accusations against Iran occurred during the 1930 Ararat rebellion; not the 1925 rebellion of Sheikh Said.
- ⁸ Colonial Office (CO) 730/5, no. 503, 20 September 1921, Sir Percy Cox to Winston Churchill. Churchill was Colonial Secretary at this time. For the wider context in which this statement occurred see Olson, *The Emergence of Kurdish Nationalism*, pp 52–90.
- ⁹ Colonial Office (CO) 730/106/17, Sir Henry Dobbs' letter of 16 March 1926 to Sir John Shuckburgh, Head of the Middle East Department at the Colonial Office.
- ¹⁰ *Ibid.*
- ¹¹ In his 16 March letter to Shuckburgh, Dobbs also stated that he thought Sir Ronald Lindsay, the chief negotiator for Britain in the talks, was wrong in suggesting that the Turks would not accept any other proposals except for the most far reaching ones which the cabinet had rejected. Dobbs stated, 'I confess that my experience

of other orientals and the precedent of the ridiculous mess of Franco–Turkish negotiations make me doubt whether the Turks are not bluffing on this point.’ Dobbs turned out to be right on this score. On 21 April 1926, the Turks abandoned their claims for *any* territory and instead demanded participation and/or shares in the oil revenues from the Mosul province. Of course the change in the Turkish position had nothing to do with their being ‘orientals’ but was due to political decisions they felt compelled to make. In this instance the Turks decided that it was more important to try to settle or, at least, contain the Kurdish question than to seek more territory which would have meant that the new Turkish republic would have had to absorb even more Kurds.

- ¹² The last seriously considered attempt by the British to raise the Kurds to rebellion in Turkey was in March 1922. See Robert W Olson, ‘The second time around: British policy towards the Kurds (1921–1922)’, *Die Welt des Islams*, 27, 1987, pp 91–102; Olson, *The Emergence of Kurdish Nationalism*, pp 76–82.
- ¹³ The literature on the Azerbaijan crisis during which the Kurdish Republic of Mahabad was created is voluminous. For one of the latest and best accounts of the crisis which has a good bibliography see Fred Lawson, ‘The Iranian crisis of 1945–1946 and the spiral model of international conflict’, *International Journal of Middle East Studies*, 21, 1989, pp 307–326.
- ¹⁴ *Ibid.* p 323.
- ¹⁵ The latest and best documented account of Israeli and US activities in this regard is Mark J Gasiorowski, *US Foreign Policy and the Shah: Building a Client State in Iran*, Ithaca: Cornell University Press, 1991, see especially pp 114–129; John K Cooley, *Payback: America’s Long War in the Middle East*, Washington, DC, Brassey’s, 1991, pp 33–46.
- ¹⁶ There was some early evidence of this cooperation in the 1960s and 1970s. See Robert W Olson, ‘Al-fatah in Turkey: its influence on the March 12 coup’, *Middle Eastern Studies*, 9 (2), 1973, pp 197–205.
- ¹⁷ According to the *New York Times*, 10 April 1991, UN sources estimated that about 750,000 Iraqi Kurds had crossed into Iran and about 280,000 into Turkey; about 300,000 were gathered at the Turkish border. Other reliable sources quote the higher figures. One of the reasons that the Turkish government gave for being unwilling to harbour more Kurdish refugees was that it was still sheltering some 25,000 refugees that had fled to Turkey after the chemical gas attacks on Halaja in summer 1988.
- ¹⁸ Martin van Bruinessen, ‘The Kurds between Iran and Iraq’, *Middle East Reports*, No. 141, July–August, 1986, p 17.
- ¹⁹ I shall use the initials PKK which is the more frequently used abbreviation, rather than the Workers’ Party of Kurdistan (wPK) which are the initials of the English translation of the party’s Kurdish name.
- ²⁰ For a good account of the origins of the PKK see Martin van Bruinessen, ‘Between guerrilla war and political murder: the Workers’ Party of Kurdistan’, *Middle East Reports*, no. 143 July–August 1988, pp 40–46; Michael M Gunter, *The Kurds in Turkey*, pp 57–96. The figures used in this paragraph are from Gunter, *The Kurds in Turkey*, pp 67–68.
- ²¹ On this and its potential implications see, Graham E Fuller, *The Center of the Universe: The Geopolitics of Iran*, Boulder: Westview Press, 1991, p 199.
- ²² I took these figures from Fuller, p 171. Fuller’s figures seem as reasonable as any others’. As the former director for long-range national estimates at the national council of the Central Intelligence Agency, his figures should be accurate.
- ²³ *Cumhuriyet*, 13 January 1987.
- ²⁴ Hugh Pope, ‘Turkey and the Kurds’, *Middle East International*, No. 415, December 1991, p 13.
- ²⁵ As of 31 December 1991, operation ‘Provide Comfort’ still had about 50 aeroplanes stationed in south-eastern Turkey, backed up by a US carrier in the eastern Mediterranean. In December 1991, the Turkish government agreed to a 6-month extension for the allied force. The Turks said, however, that this would be the last extension.
- ²⁶ *Cumhuriyet*, 19 October 1991, p 5.
- ²⁷ *Cumhuriyet*, 2 November, 1991, p 7.
- ²⁸ This was a constant position in the leftist oriented newspapers and periodicals. For example, see Doğu Perinçek’s views expressed in *2000 İkinin’e Doğru*, 17 November 1991; also the 10 November issue of the same magazine devotes its leading article to this topic. Of course, leftist groups in Turkey are opposed to a greater, especially an expansive role for Turkey in northern Iraq, the Caucasus or Central Asia, as this would be accomplished at the expense of the working class in Turkey.
- ²⁹ For a good overview of Turkey’s overall foreign policy options in the Middle East and in Europe, consult Philip Robins, *Turkey and the Middle East*, London: Royal Institute of International Affairs, 1991, pp 100–111.
- ³⁰ The leading article in the 3 November 1991 issue of the weekly magazine *Nokta* quotes Doğu Perinçek as stating that talks between various Kurdish organisations began sometime in 1987 or ‘probably earlier’. The talks were between officials of the National Intelligence Organisation of Turkey (commonly referred to by its Turkish initials, MIT) and various Kurdish leaders. Perinçek did not state whether Masud Barzani, Jalal Talabani or their representatives were also included in these earlier talks.
- ³¹ In his statement to *Nokta*, Perinçek actually mentions the individuals who liaised between the government and Kurds.
- ³² *Ibid.*